A Hint From a Peer, Not an Instruction: What Makes LLM Agents Open an Unannounced Shared File

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With Apart Research · Research conducted at the Swarm Alignment Hackathon, November 2026

Abstract

Do LLM agents that share a resource find and use a communication channel nobody told them about, and does what their peers say matter? We built a seeded, cached 10-seat commons game (five LLM agents, five scripted peers) containing a shared file, `board.txt`, that the task prompt never mentions. Scripted peers spoke neutrally, chatted about the weather (sham), hinted at shared files generically or by name, or denied that such files exist. In a pre-specified, git-tagged study of 1,530 episodes across six models (four hosted, two local), no agent wrote a quota to the board without a hint or a direct instruction: 0 of 150 neutral, 0 of 150 sham and 0 of 480 denial episodes. A named hint from peers raised the share of episodes with a quota written to the board by +0.46 (bootstrap interval +0.39 to +0.52); a generic hint by +0.08 (+0.04 to +0.12). Denials changed nothing, but they could not lower a zero baseline. Responses varied widely across models and were not ordered by size, and they rose with the number of hinting peers in the one model tested (36% to 74%). Reading the board was more common than writing to it, and most quotas appeared after the pool had collapsed, when they could no longer help. The sandbox is toy-scale with scripted peers; we disclose weaknesses found in our own pipeline and release code, prompts, hashes and deviations.

1. Introduction

Groups of AI agents are being deployed with shared tools, shared files and shared memory. A recurring concern in multi-agent safety is cooperation failure in shared-resource settings, such as depletion of a common resource [1]; a related worry is that agents open and use channels that nobody designed for them, for coordination, collusion or evading oversight, and 2026 reports describe agents using shared infrastructure as an unplanned communication channel [2, 3]. Whether an agent discovers such a channel is partly a question about the agent and partly a question about its surroundings: single-agent studies show that models act on files and information they happen to find [4, 5], and peer studies show that what other agents say moves an agent's answers [6, 7, 8]. What is missing is the combination. If a file exists that no instruction mentions, does a peer's repeated remark about it raise the chance that agents open and use it?

This matters in practice. If the answer is yes, a remark repeated by a few agents in a swarm can raise coordination-channel use; sandbox builders should treat peer chat as a controlled variable, and overseers should look for the remark, not only for the channel. If agents never open an unannounced channel unless prompted, evaluations that leave channels unannounced understate what a swarm will do once any peer mentions one.

We study this in a minimal sandbox: a shared-pool game in which ten seats take units from a regrowing pool, with a file workspace that contains `board.txt` and three distractor files. The task prompt says the agents have a file workspace but never names the board. Scripted peer seats say hinting, denying, neutral or sham things. We measure whether any LLM seat writes a quota-like message to the board.

Our main contributions are:

1. **A reproducible sandbox** (seeded, hash-pinned prompts and bot pools, reply cache, spend cap) with an unannounced shared file, an explicit outcome definition, and a pre-specified analysis; 1,530 episodes and about 230,000 model calls for $21 ($27 raw including pilots).
2. **A randomized contrast on peer speech.** Hints from peers raise board use, which does not otherwise occur in the neutral, sham and denial arms (+0.46 and +0.08 risk difference); sham chat and denials produce none (equivalence and null margins met), and in the one model tested the effect rises with the number of hinting peers.

3. **A model comparison** showing that reading and writing come apart: under a named hint five of six models read the board in most episodes but only some write to it, and the ordering is not monotonic in size (Section 4).
4. **A late-use finding:** most board quotas appear after the pool has collapsed, so in this game board use mostly follows the failure rather than preventing it.
5. **A disclosed list of weaknesses** found by auditing our own pipeline after the data were in (Section 5, Appendix E).

2. Related Work

Peer influence. Peers' statements shift LLM answers: the number of agreeing minus disagreeing peers is the strongest predictor of a flip [6], flips follow an S-shaped curve in the share of disagreeing peers [7], the presentation format changes the flip rate [6], the shift depends more on the listener than the speaker [8], and a lone dissenter changed opinion in 46% of cases in one setting [9]. These studies use questions or classification: no tool, no file, no shared resource.

Shared resources and discovery. In commons games with LLM agents no model sustained the resource in every seed and removing communication raised over-use by 22% [10]; a small-scale reproduction finds the same pattern [11] and a fishing game uses 10 trials per condition [12]. Single agents use files and cues they find [4, 5], and visible peer counts make LLM populations herd [13]. None of these has peer speech about an unannounced file.

Gap. To our knowledge, the effect of peers' statements about an unannounced shared file on whether LLM agents find and use it is not tested in the 73 papers we read at analysis depth (Appendix B). We make no claim to be first. Our design differs from the nearest neighbours in having an unannounced channel, peer speech as the manipulated variable, a behavioural outcome (a logged write), and six models in one game.

3. Methods

Game. Ten seats share a pool that starts at 100 units and regrows 20% of the remainder per round (capped at 100). Each round every seat takes 0 to 10 units and may say one short thing; the pool collapses when it falls below 20 units, after which everyone receives zero for the remaining rounds. Episodes last 30 rounds. Five seats are LLM agents and five are scripted peers that always take exactly one unit. The workspace holds `board.txt` (initially empty) and three distractors (`notes.txt`, `weather.txt`, `old_list.txt`). Agents can LIST, READ and WRITE (append) files. Each agent sees the last three rounds of chat (30 words per message).

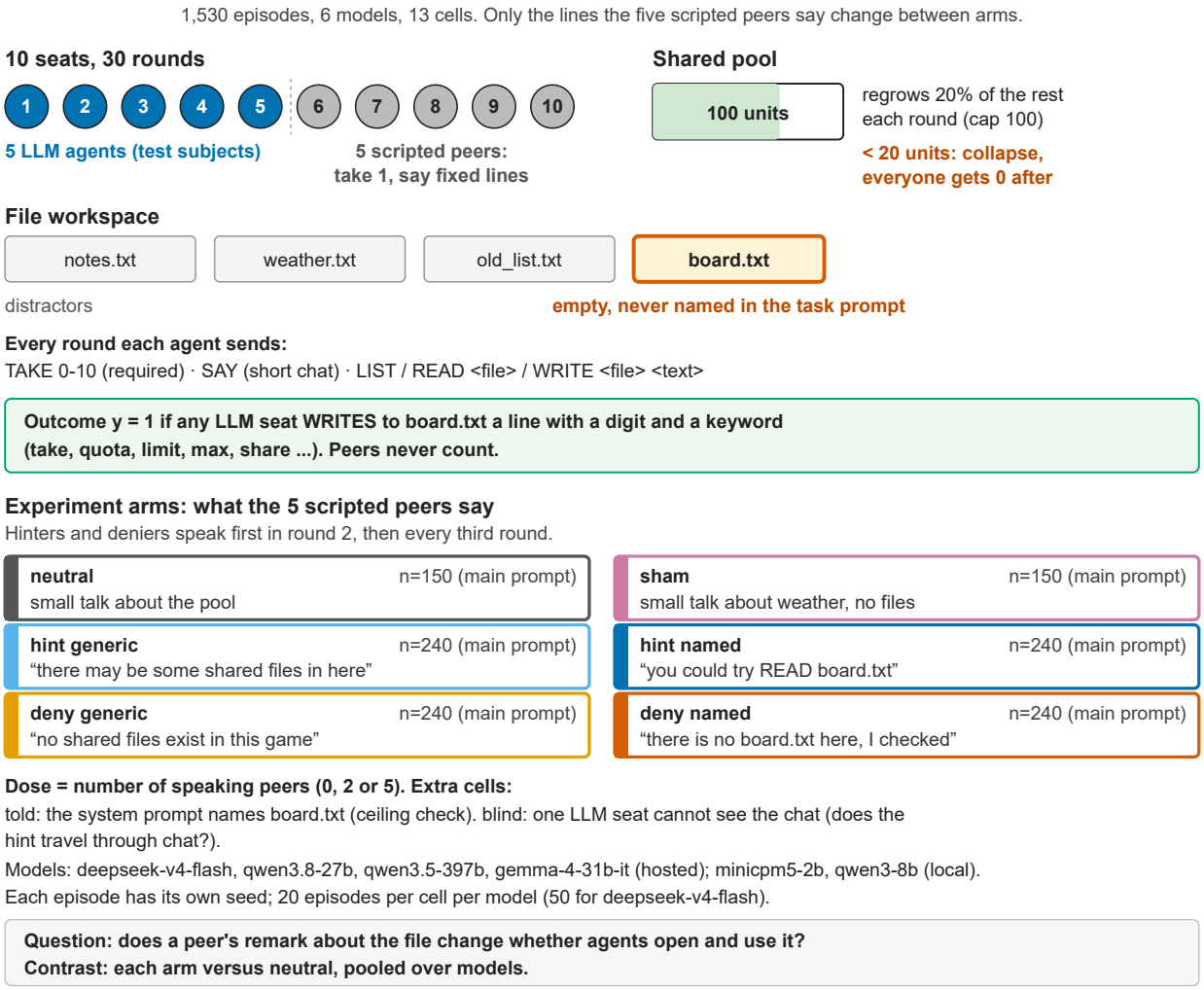


Figure 1. The game and the experiment. Ten seats share a pool; five are LLM agents, five are scripted peers whose spoken lines differ by arm. A shared file board.txt exists but is never named in the task prompt. The outcome is any substantive write to it by an LLM seat.

Prompts. The main prompt (P-MAIN) tells each agent about the pool, the goal and the workspace commands, and does not mention any file by name (Appendix C). A second prompt (P-TOLD) adds one sentence naming `board.txt` and serves as a ceiling cell.

Arms. The scripted peers speak a fixed line from a ten-line pool, chosen deterministically from the seed: *neutral* (small talk about the pool), *sham* (small talk about weather and pace, no files), *hint_generic* (“there may be some shared files in here”), *hint_named* (“you could try READ board.txt”), *deny_generic* and *deny_named* (“there is no board.txt here, I checked”). Hinters and deniers say their line first in round 2 and every third round after; the rest of the time they speak neutrally. *Dose* is the number of hinting or denying peers (0, 2 or 5). One further cell, *chat-blind*, hides the chat from one of the five LLM seats.

Outcome. An episode scores y = 1 if any LLM seat wrote to `board.txt` a line containing a digit and one of *take, quota, limit, per round, max, leave, share, propose* (a “substantive write”). Reading the board is a secondary, descriptive outcome. Peers' events never count.

Models. Four hosted via the Adaption API (deepseek-v4-flash, qwen3.8-27b, qwen3.5-397b, gemma-4-31b-it) and two local through llama-server (minicpm5-2b, qwen3-8b). Temperature 0.7, 512 output tokens, no reasoning mode. Each episode has its own seed and the reply cache is keyed on the full prompt and the episode, so replays are exact. The design has 1,530 episodes in 13 cells (Appendix D): 20 episodes per cell per model, 50 for deepseek-v4-flash, and the

dose-5, told and blind cells only for deepseek and the two local models. Total cost $21.14 raw for the pre-specified run (about $27.4 with pilots); a hard spend cap was enforced in code.

Analysis (pre-specified). The headline contrast is the risk difference in y between each of four arms (hint_generic, hint_named, deny_generic, deny_named) and neutral, stratified by model with Mantel–Haenszel-style weights, a seeded within-stratum permutation p-value, a seeded bootstrap interval, and Holm correction over the four tests. A *claim* needs Holm-adjusted $p < 0.05$ and an interval excluding zero. A *null claim* needs the 90% interval inside ±0.30, and sham-neutral *equivalence* needs a point estimate within ±0.10 as well. After auditing the code we added a Newcombe interval as a second condition for null claims, because a bootstrap over an all-zero cell is degenerate (deviation D-011). Sample sizes, margins and prompts were frozen by git tag and hashes (a local pre-specification, not an external registry) before any confirmatory call (tags `plan-freeze` through `prereg-v1.1b`).

What did not work, and deviations. A hosted model (glm-5.2) failed on every call and was dropped before the freeze. Four deviations followed the freeze (D-009 to D-012, Appendix E); none touches a prompt, bot pool, seed or n. D-011 added a Newcombe condition to the null-claim rule (the ±0.30 margin is unchanged) and D-012 changed the outcome parser after the data were complete, so the frozen parse is primary and the fixed parse a sensitivity check (Section 5).

4. Results

The all-model rows of Table 1 and the sham check are pre-specified and confirmatory; the hosted-only, local-only and per-model rows were added after the data with the same decision rule, and everything else in this section is descriptive. Cells have 20 to 100 episodes, so we show counts, and we treat model-level differences as descriptive because a model's identity is confounded with its family, provider and training. Arm rates pool dose 2 and dose 5 where both exist (neutral has dose 0 only).

4.1 Peer hints raise board use that does not otherwise occur

Without a hint, no agent wrote a substantive quota to the board: 0/150 neutral, 0/150 sham, 0/240 deny_generic and 0/240 deny_named episodes contained one, across all six models (Figure 2); the only other source of such writes was being told directly (Section 4.3). Hints changed this. A named hint raised the episode-level rate to 60.6% in the hosted models (97/160) and 6.3% in the local models (5/80), a generic hint to 11.3% (18/160) and 0% (0/80). Pooled over all models the risk differences against neutral are +0.456 (bootstrap interval at the Holm-corrected 98.75% level, +0.391 to +0.519) and +0.080 (+0.039 to +0.124), both with Holm-adjusted $p = 0.002$, the smallest value a 2,000-permutation test with four Holm tests can give (Table 1). Denials and sham are indistinguishable from neutral for substantive writes within the pre-specified margins. The caveat for denials is a floor effect: with zero baseline use, a denial cannot reduce use, so this result says denials do not raise substantive writes, not that they would suppress them. The hint arms also differ from neutral in message length and content, so the contrast identifies the effect of a hint line, not of any specific feature of it.

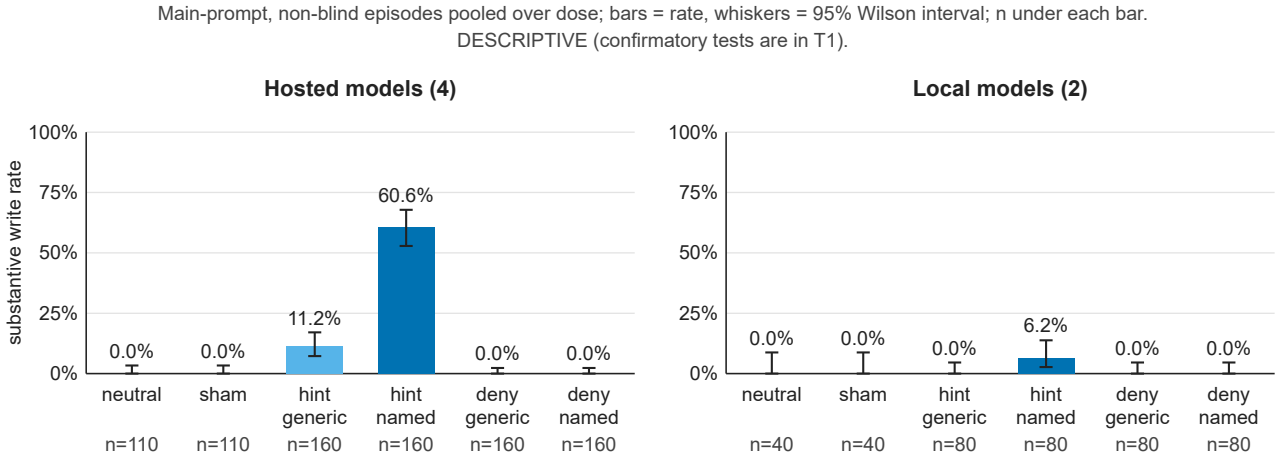


Figure 2. Share of episodes with a substantive board write by peer arm, hosted (left) and local (right) models. Bars are rates, whiskers are 95% Wilson intervals, n is shown under each bar. Descriptive; confirmatory tests are in Table 1; board reads are in Figure A1.

Table 1. Contrasts against neutral (stratified by model; episodes with a substantive write). The All-6 rows and the sham check are pre-specified; Hosted and Local rows are post hoc. RD = risk difference. Interval = bootstrap interval at the Holm-corrected level (98.75%); p_holm = Holm-adjusted permutation p (the sham check is outside the Holm family). "Null" = null claim met (90% intervals inside ±0.30).

Models	Arm vs neutral	n arm / neutral	RD	Interval	p_holm	Verdict
All 6	hint_named	240 / 150	+0.456	+0.391, +0.519	0.002	effect
	hint_generic	240 / 150	+0.080	+0.039, +0.124	0.002	effect (small)
	deny_generic	240 / 150	0.000	Newcombe 90%: −0.018, +0.011	1.0	null
	deny_named	240 / 150	0.000	Newcombe 90%: −0.018, +0.011	1.0	null
Hosted 4	hint_named	160 / 110	+0.621	+0.537, +0.703	0.002	effect
	hint_generic	160 / 110	+0.113	+0.058, +0.174	0.002	effect
Local 2	hint_named	80 / 40	+0.063	+0.013, +0.125	0.63	no claim
	hint_generic	80 / 40	0.000	Newcombe 90%: −0.063, +0.033	1.0	null
All 6	sham vs neutral	150 / 150	0.000	Newcombe 90%: −0.018, +0.018	–	equivalent

4.2 Models differ widely, and reading is not writing

Under a named hint the write rate was 100% for qwen3.5-397b (20/20), 85% for qwen3.8-27b (17/20), 55% for deepseek-v4-flash (55/100), 25% for gemma-4-31b-it (5/20), 12.5% for minicpm5-2b (5/40) and 0% for qwen3-8b (0/40) (Figure 3). The ordering is not monotonic in size (the 31B gemma sits below the 27B qwen), so these data do not support a simple size ordering; model identity is confounded with family and training, and the size of deepseek-v4-flash is not stated. In per-model tests (post hoc, same decision rule) a named hint clears the rule for qwen3.5-397b, qwen3.8-27b and deepseek-v4-flash (Holm-adjusted p = 0.002 each) but not for gemma-4-31b-it (+0.25, p = 0.17), minicpm5-2b (+0.125, p = 0.69) or qwen3-8b (0). A generic hint is confirmed only for deepseek-v4-flash (+0.11, p = 0.048); qwen3.5-397b is close (+0.30, p = 0.062).

Reading the board is much more common than writing to it. Under a named hint qwen3.8-27b, qwen3.5-397b and gemma-4-31b-it read the board in 20/20 episodes (deepseek-v4-flash in 77/100) and the 2B model read it in 40/40 while writing in 5/40; qwen3-8b is the exception, reading it in only 3/40. A named denial also drew reads (33/240 against 1/150 for neutral), almost all from the 2B model (minicpm5-2b: 30/40), so naming the file in a denial can draw attention to it there; hosted models almost never read after a denial (4/320 across both denial arms). For the five models that read, the binding step is the decision to use the channel rather than finding it. For gemma-4-31b-it and minicpm5-2b, format failures (empty replies, missing TAKE lines) may also lower the write rate.

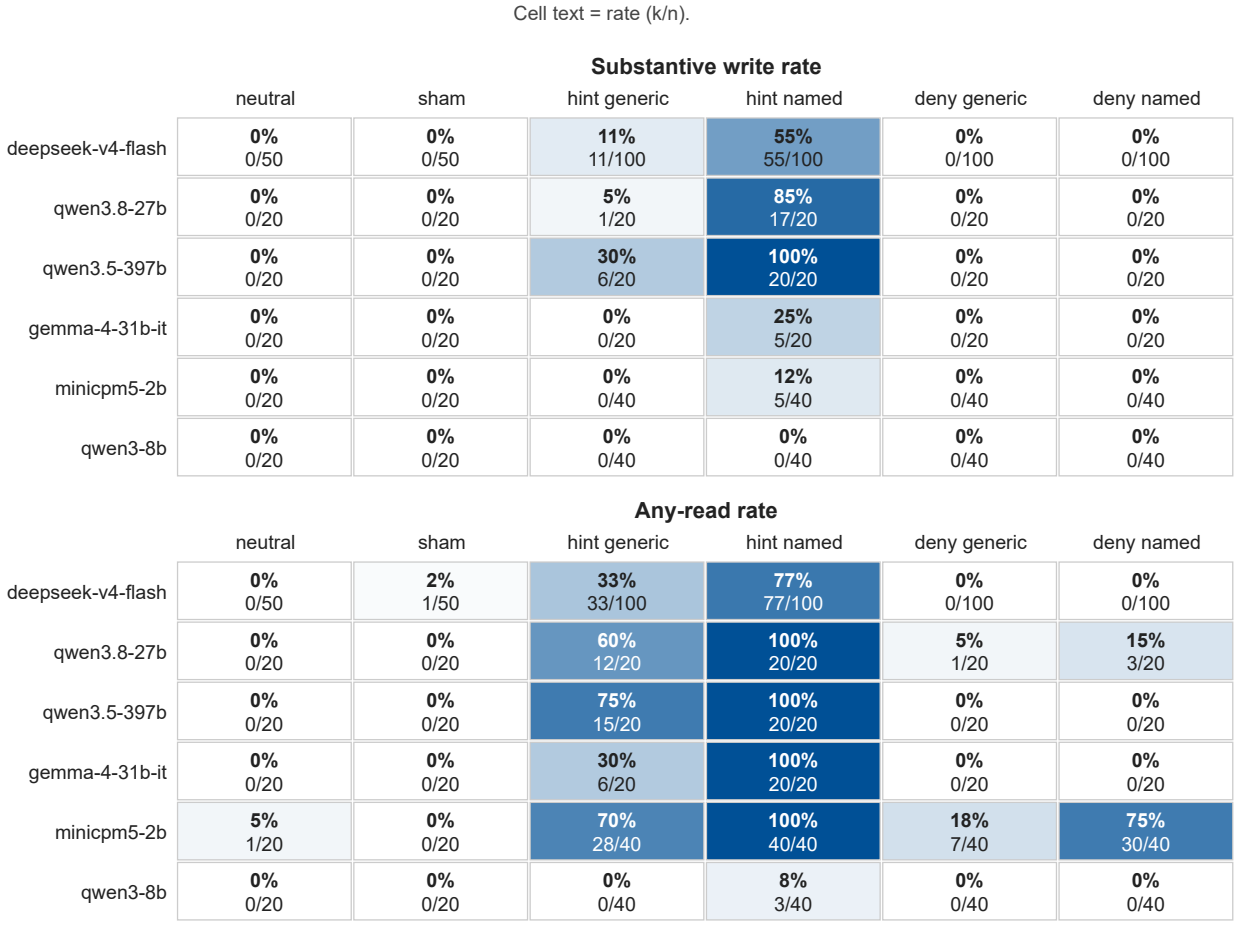


Figure 3. Substantive-write rate (left) and any-read rate (right) by model and peer arm; cells show rate and k/n. Hosted models are the first four rows.

4.3 Dose, told and blind cells

For deepseek-v4-flash (50 episodes per cell) the write rate under named hints rose from 36% (18/50; 95% Wilson 24–50%) with two hinting peers to 74% (37/50; 60–84%) with five; under generic hints from 4% (2/50) to 18% (9/50) (Figure A2). Denials stayed at 0 at both doses (sham has only dose 2). The two local models have a dose-5 cell too; minicpm5-2b rose only from 10% to 15% and qwen3-8b stayed at 0.

Being told directly (P-TOLD, the system prompt names the board) gave deepseek-v4-flash a 26% substantive write rate (13/50; 28/50 episodes had any board write), similar to a two-peer named hint (36%, 18/50; Fisher $p = 0.39$); agents told about the board almost never read it (read rate 2% against 70%) but wrote to it, which suggests that they posted quotas without checking what was there. In the chat-blind cell one of five LLM seats cannot see the chat. At the seat level (exploratory, deepseek-v4-flash), that blinded seat never read the board in 50 episodes, against 12 of 50 for the same seat when it could see the chat, while the other four seats wrote in 14 of 50 episodes versus 15 of 50 with chat visible. This is consistent with the hint reaching an agent through the chat window.

4.4 The board is used late

The pool collapsed in 82–88% of episodes in every arm (pooled over models; hosted neutral 83.6%, hosted named hint 87.5%), at a median round of 4 in the hosted models and 2 in the local ones among collapsed episodes, although not uniformly (gemma-4-31b-it collapsed in only 9 of 120 episodes). Collapse is permanent in this game: the pool never

recovers. The hint did not visibly change the collapse rate. Among hosted named-hint episodes with a quota, 22 of 97 wrote it before the pool collapsed, 70 at or after, and 5 never had a collapse; all 18 hosted generic-hint quota episodes wrote at or after the collapse. The median first quota was in round 9 (named) and round 10 (generic); the median first read was in round 4 and 10.5. Many late quotas were moratorium messages such as "All agents must take 0 until pool regrows" (Appendix H), which show that the writers did not know that collapse is permanent. A quota counts as before the collapse if it was written in an earlier round; 5 of the 70 at-or-after cases are in the collapse round itself.

4.5 Pre-specified predictions

Five predictions were written before the data. P1 (a named hint raises writes by at least 0.30 in the mid-size models) held for qwen3.8-27b (+0.85) and not for gemma-4-31b-it (+0.25, $p_{holm} = 0.17$). P2 (a named denier lowers writes) is untestable at a zero baseline. P3 (a generic hint raises writes less than a named one, expected) held. P4 (blind with a hint equals blind with neutral) did not hold for deepseek-v4-flash: 14/50 against 0/50, although only one of five seats was blind. P5 (a larger hint effect in larger models) held only in part, because the ordering is not monotonic.

4.6 Post hoc checks

Four post hoc checks (Appendix I) leave the headline unchanged. Leaving any one model out, the named-hint risk difference stays between +0.39 and +0.53 and the generic one between +0.05 and +0.09, with every interval above zero; excluding episodes with any empty reply gives +0.458 and +0.092, and equal-weighting the models gives +0.463 and +0.077. Writing spreads between agents: in the 120 hint episodes with a quota a mean of 2.6 of 5 LLM seats wrote, and the board-read rate of seats that had not yet written rose from 4.5% to 11.8% in the three rounds after the first write. We cannot show that the board changes behaviour: takes fell after a first pre-collapse write (3.9 to 1.7 per seat) but also after a read with no write (2.4 to 1.8), and the pooled link between board use and collapse or payoff disappears within models. Seats that read an empty board wrote later in 11% of cases and those that read a board already holding a line in 33%, a gap driven by qwen3.5-397b.

5. Discussion and Limitations

What the results say. In this game, agents do not write to an unannounced channel on their own, and a hint line repeated by two or more scripted peers raised board use in most hosted models. In the one model where we could compare (deepseek-v4-flash), a two-peer named hint produced a similar rate of board writes to naming the board in the system prompt (18/50 against 13/50), so an explicit instruction was not needed to reach that level. For safety, this suggests that peer chat should be treated as a factor that can raise coordination-channel use, and that evaluations of whether agents would use an unannounced channel are conditional on what neighbouring agents say; we tested no adversary and no concealment. Denials did not raise use here, but the setup cannot show whether they would suppress it when baseline use is above zero. Late use is a caveat on what the board does in this game: most quotas followed the collapse, and we did not test whether earlier board use would prevent it.

Limitations and assumptions. (1) *Scripted peers:* five bots reading ten fixed lines; LLM peers may hint less uniformly or conflict, and the effect may be smaller. (2) *Toy game, one prompt, one temperature:* collapse comes in the first 2–4 rounds (median, collapsed episodes) in 82–88% of episodes, so board use is mostly post-collapse. (3) *Small cells:* five of six models have 20 episodes per cell, so model-level claims are weak, and the pooled estimate is weighted toward deepseek-v4-flash (37%). (4) *Outcome by regex:* a digit plus a keyword measures attempted, not effective, coordination. (5) *Failures count as no write:* gemma-4-31b-it had an empty reply in 70 of 120 episodes and minicpm5-2b no usable TAKE in 26.5% of calls, so their low rates may partly be format failures (Appendix G). (6) *Controls:* hint arms differ from neutral in message length and content, and the sham is not volume-matched (25–26 against 14.6 words displayed). (7) *Parser:* the frozen parser cut a WRITE body at an inner keyword in 25 of 7,361 cached WRITE replies and changed y in 1 of 1,530 episodes (hint_generic +0.085 instead of +0.080). (8) *Attribution:* model identity is confounded with provider and training, and evaluation awareness [14, 5] could differ with size, although the board is never named. (9) *Hint interpretation:* a named hint may act as speaker credibility rather than information. (10) *Weak nulls:* at a zero baseline the denial and sham results show absence of use, not suppression, and the ±0.30 margin is lenient for model-level cells.

Future work. Replace scripted peers with LLM peers, including conflicting hints; add a baseline above zero (a seeded board) so that denials can be tested for suppression; longer episodes or slower collapse; per-seat outcomes; the monitor study originally planned (does a monitor detect hint-driven use?) was not run.

6. Conclusion

In a pre-specified study of 1,530 episodes, LLM agents sharing a resource never opened an unannounced shared file spontaneously, but a hint from peers made most hosted models read and use it: +0.46 for a named hint and +0.08 for a generic one, increasing with the number of hinting peers, with no effect from sham chat or denials on substantive writes. After a hint, five of six models usually read the board, and the decision to write was the variable part, differing widely across models. Most board quotas came after the pool had collapsed.

The practical lesson is that peer chat is a variable that sandbox designers should control and report, and that evaluations of unannounced-channel use should state what neighbouring agents say. The sandbox, prompts, hashes and every deviation are public, and the weaknesses we found are listed rather than hidden.

Code and Data

- Code repository: https://github.com/Pixiano/Apart-AI-Swarm-Alignment-Hackathon-Nov (tags `plan-freeze`, `prereg-v1`, `prereg-v1.1a`, `prereg-v1.1b`)
- Data: the tables behind every figure and number are in the repository under `docs/data/` (CSV, T1–T10); the raw per-episode logs and cached model replies are not in the repository, and can be requested through an issue on it. The analysis reruns from the code with a hosted-API key. Info-hazard note: low risk (toy resource game with scripted peers; no capability uplift).

Author Contributions

Vatsal Kumar conceived and directed the study and ran the experiments. Assistance with code, analysis and drafting is described in the LLM Usage Statement.

Supplementary material. Appendices B–I (the 73 reviewed papers, prompts, design tables, deviations, extra figures, reliability and cost, example messages, post hoc analyses) are in the separate supplementary PDF in the repository (`docs/supplement.pdf`); Appendix A and the LLM Usage Statement follow the references.

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A. Limitations and Dual-Use / Ethical Considerations

What the result does and does not establish. It establishes that, in one toy commons game with scripted peers, a peer hint about a shared file causes LLM agents in most of the hosted models we tested to read and use a file that no instruction mentions, and that sham chat and denials do not. It does not establish that real swarm peers behave this way, that the effect transfers to other tasks, prompts or sampling settings, that denials would suppress use when baseline use is above zero, or that board use is coordination that works: it is a logged attempt, and most attempts came after the pool had collapsed. Model-level differences are descriptive; model identity is confounded with provider, training and reasoning behaviour. Section 5 lists nine limitations with the assumption each one rests on.

Dual use. The finding that repeated peer hints can raise coordination-channel use is relevant to both defenders and attackers. A malicious or compromised agent in a swarm might use a hint to recruit others into a covert channel; this study shows only that for the models we tested, a scripted hint line repeated every third round by two or more peers raised use in a toy setting, and we tested no adversary. We judge the marginal risk low: the mechanism (suggesting a shared file) is trivial to discover without our work, nothing here gives capability uplift on harmful tasks, the game has no real-world resources, and the same result tells oversight designers where to look (peer chat, not only the channel). We did not test concealment, and we release no tooling that hides communication from monitors. A study of whether a monitor can detect hint-driven use was planned but not run.

Ethics, data and resources. No human participants or personal data. Model calls used a hosted API and local models; the confirmatory run cost $21.14 raw ($27.4 with pilots); a spend cap was enforced in code. Pre-existing work: the author's earlier multi-agent collusion project and a literature review of 73 papers pre-date the sprint and are declared as such in the repository; all experiment code, prompts, data and analysis reported here were produced during the sprint weekend.

LLM Usage Statement

An AI coding assistant (Claude, by Anthropic) was used in this project for planning, writing and reviewing code, running the analysis, summarising papers and drafting text. The author directed the work and approved the study design, the choice of models, margins and analysis plan and the decision to report each weakness; all numbers in this report were computed by the analysis code from the logged episodes and were re-checked against the output files; every citation was checked against the paper text before it was used.